



THE DARK SIDE OF SOCIAL MEDIA

From Social Media Engagement to Materialism and Consumer Behaviour

THE BIG QUESTION

What does the data say about social-media engagement and consumption?

RESEARCH QUESTION

Does social media influence how we consume?

We test associations between social-media intensity, materialism and three consumption behaviours.

CORRELATION, NOT CAUSATION



DATASET & METHOD

Cleaning, construct scoring, exploration and Pearson correlation analysis.

400

RESPONDENTS

158

VARIABLES

116

LIKERT ITEMS

0

**DUPLICATE
ROWS**

0

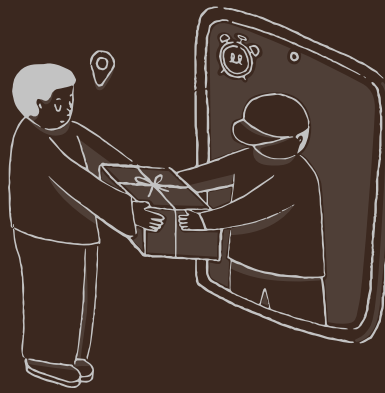
**MISSING
VALUES**

SIX CORE CONSTRUCTS

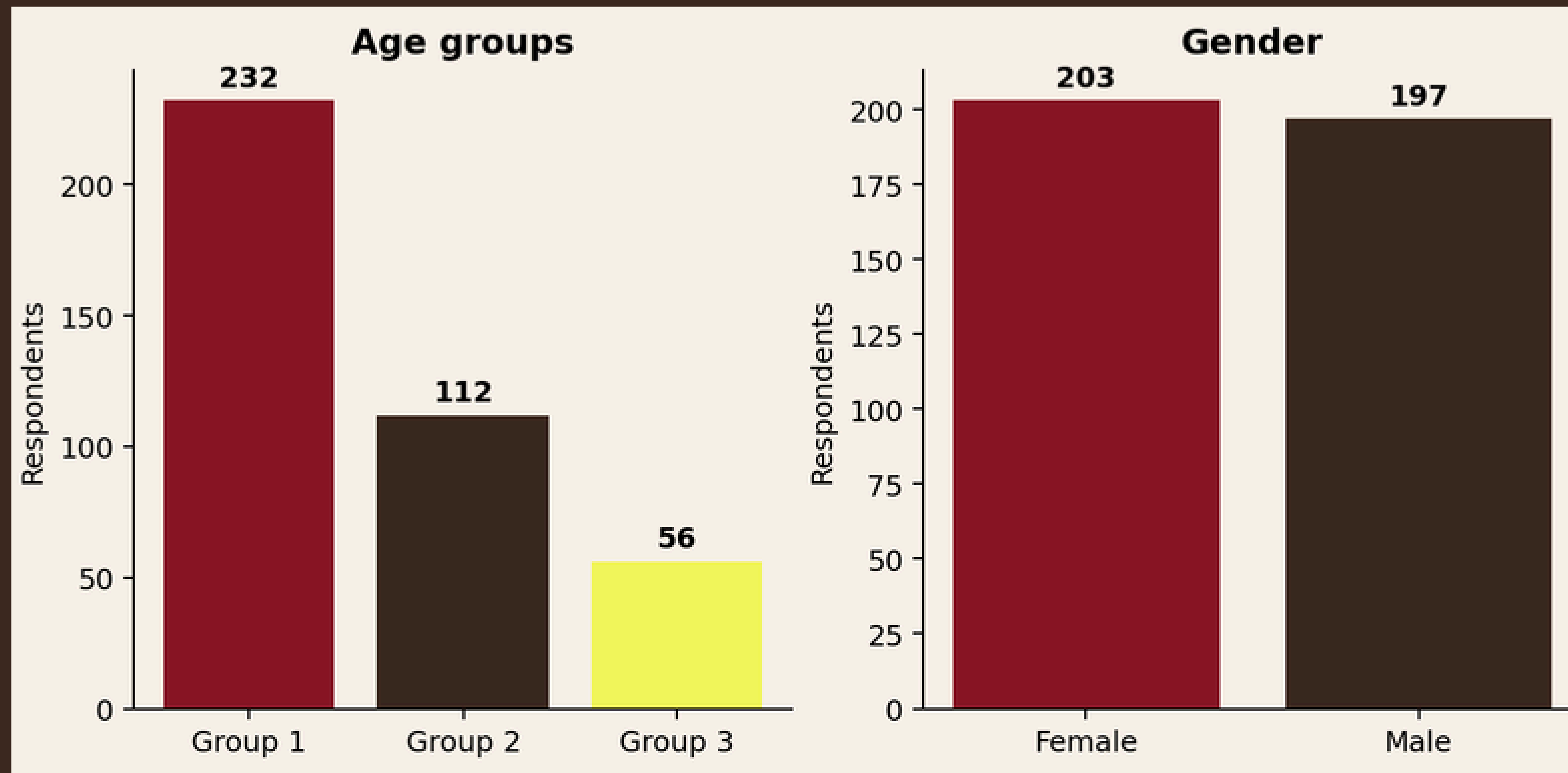
- Materialism • Social Media Intensity • Content Attitude
- Compulsive Buying • Conspicuous Buying • Impulse Buying



WHO TOOK PART?



400 respondents; gender is almost evenly split, while the dataset uses three age-group codes.



KEY PROFILE

Female – 203

Male – 197

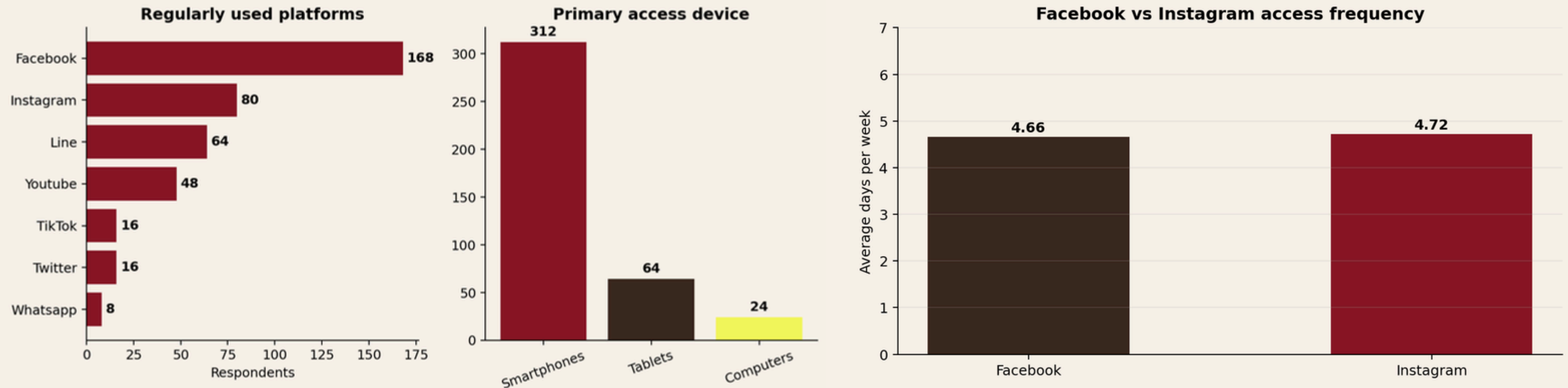
Age Group 1: 232

Age Group 2: 112

Age Group 3: 56

HOW DO RESPONDENTS USE SOCIAL MEDIA?

Platform use and access-device patterns, plus Facebook vs Instagram frequency.



312 smartphone users

Instagram: 4.72 days/week

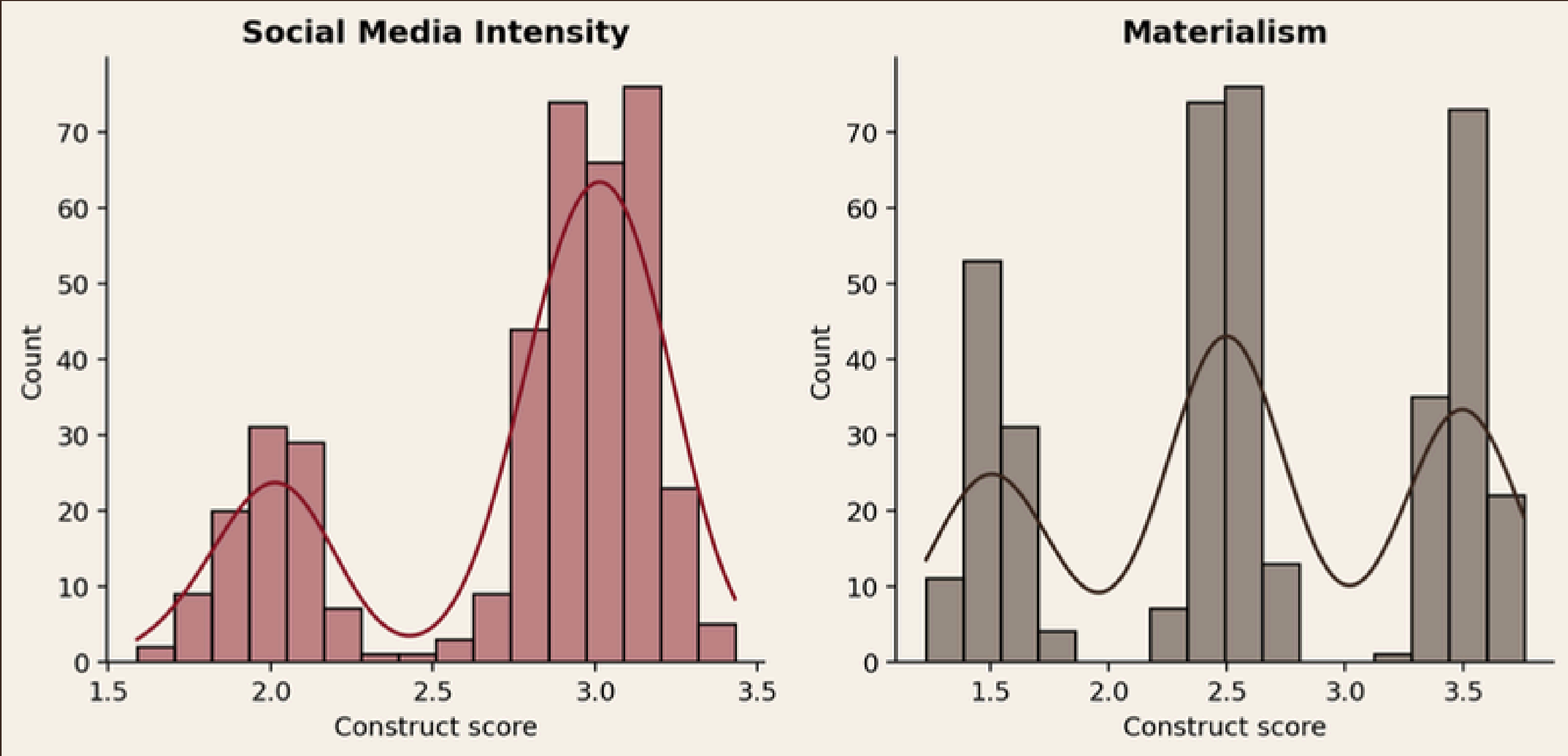
Facebook: 4.66 days/week

- The main access pattern is smartphone-led.
- Instagram is marginally higher than Facebook in average weekly access.



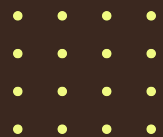
DISTRIBUTIONS: INTENSITY & MATERIALISM

Most scores cluster around the middle of the construct scales.



Mean SMI = 2.75

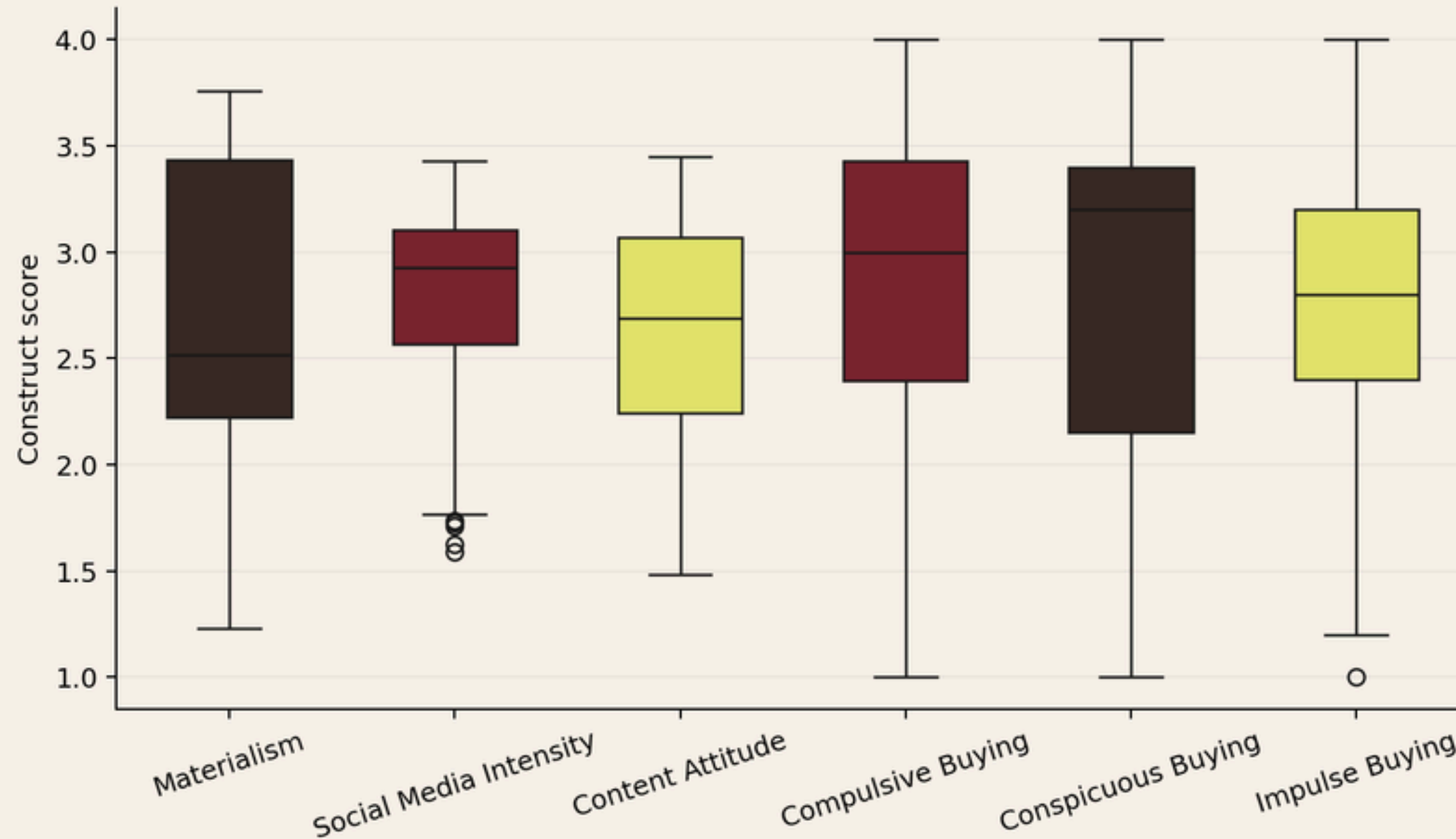
Mean Materialism = 2.58



THE BEHAVIOURAL LANDSCAPE

Six construct-level scores provide the overall picture.

Six core construct distributions



AVERAGE SCORES

Materialism 2.58

Social Media Intensity 2.75

Content Attitude 2.62

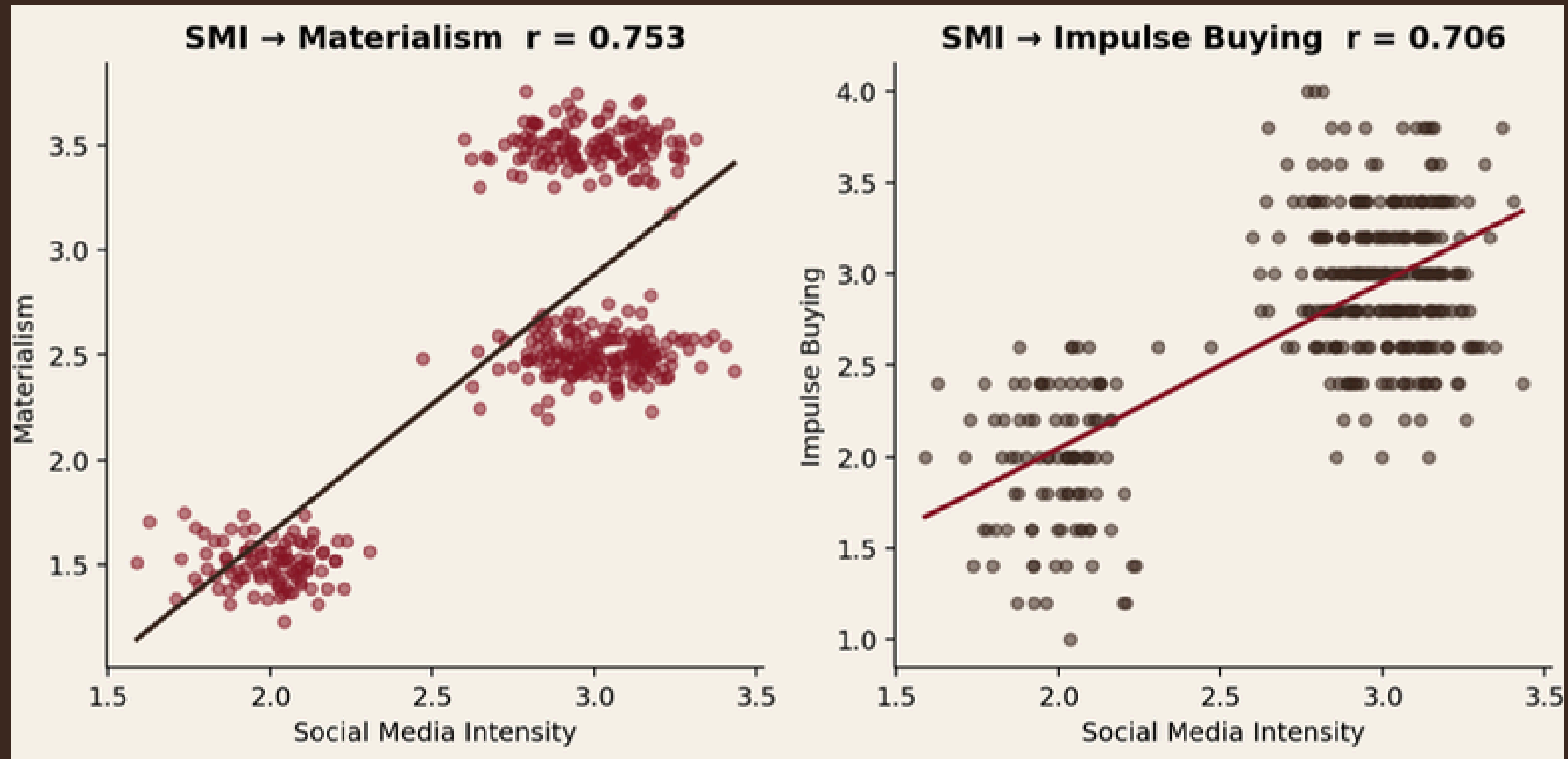
Compulsive Buying 2.79

Conspicuous Buying 2.81

Impulse Buying 2.73

THE TWO DIRECT LINKS

Social Media Intensity is positively associated with materialism and impulse buying.

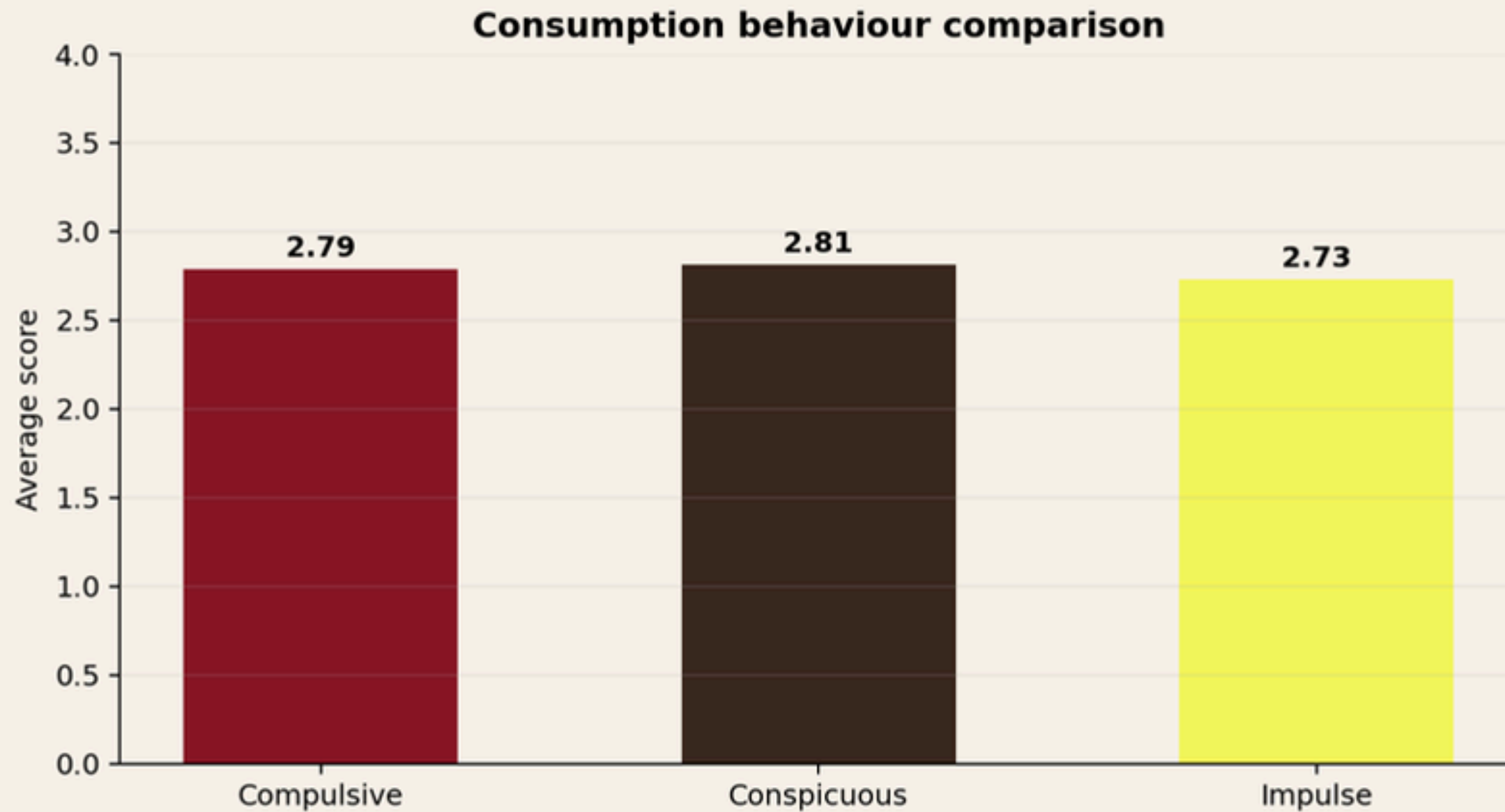


SMI ↔ Materialism: $r = 0.753$, $p < 0.001$

SMI ↔ Impulse Buying: $r = 0.706$, $p < 0.001$

WHAT KIND OF BUYING BEHAVIOUR STANDS OUT?

Conspicuous buying has the highest average score, but the three means are close.



HIGHEST: 2.81

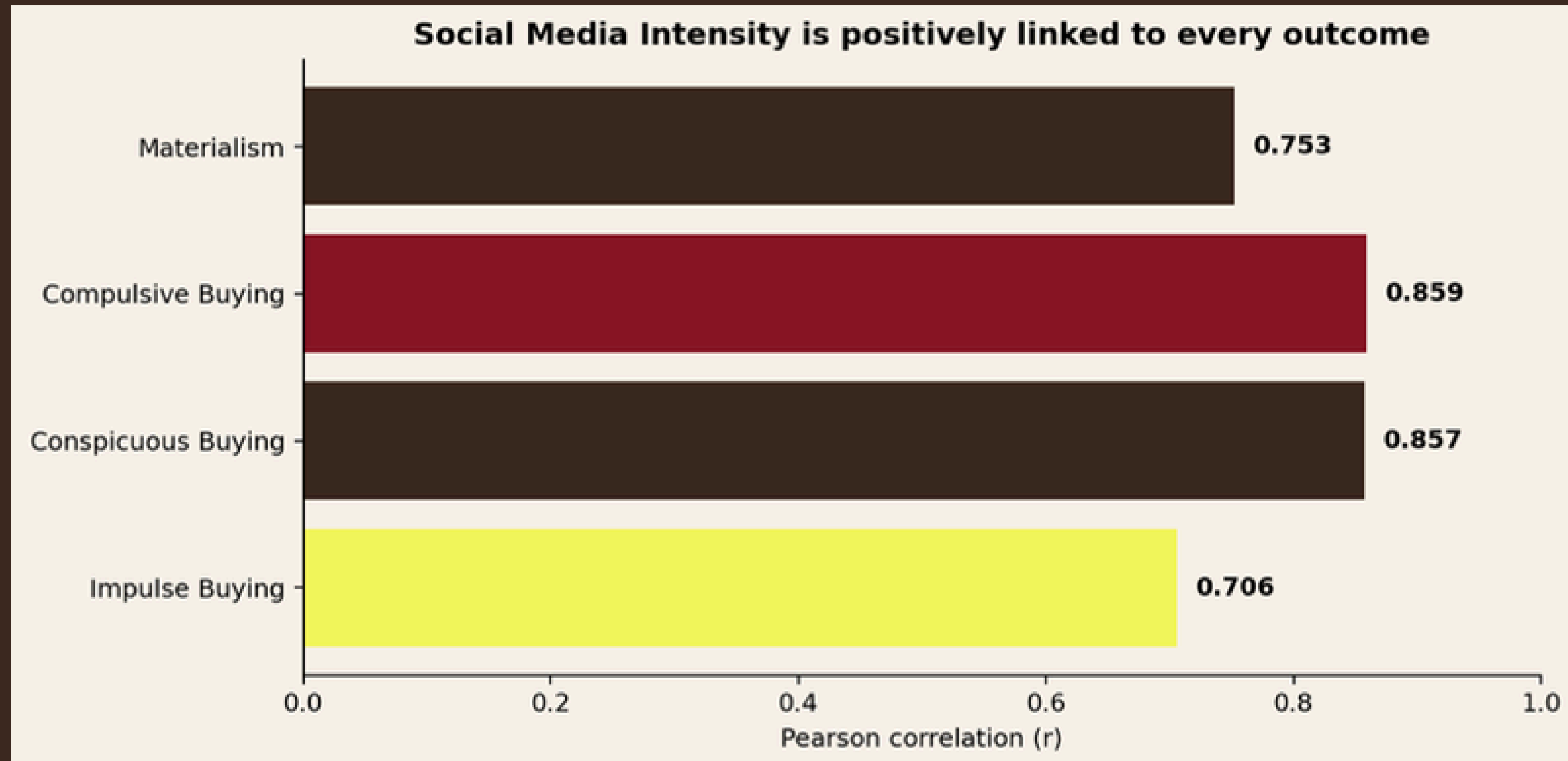
Conspicuous buying

- **Compulsive 2.79**
- **Conspicuous 2.81**
- **Impulse 2.73**

Average levels are similar, so the more important story is how these behaviours relate to social-media and materialism measures.

SOCIAL MEDIA INTENSITY: THE BROADER PATTERN

Higher social-media intensity is positively related to all four focal outcomes.

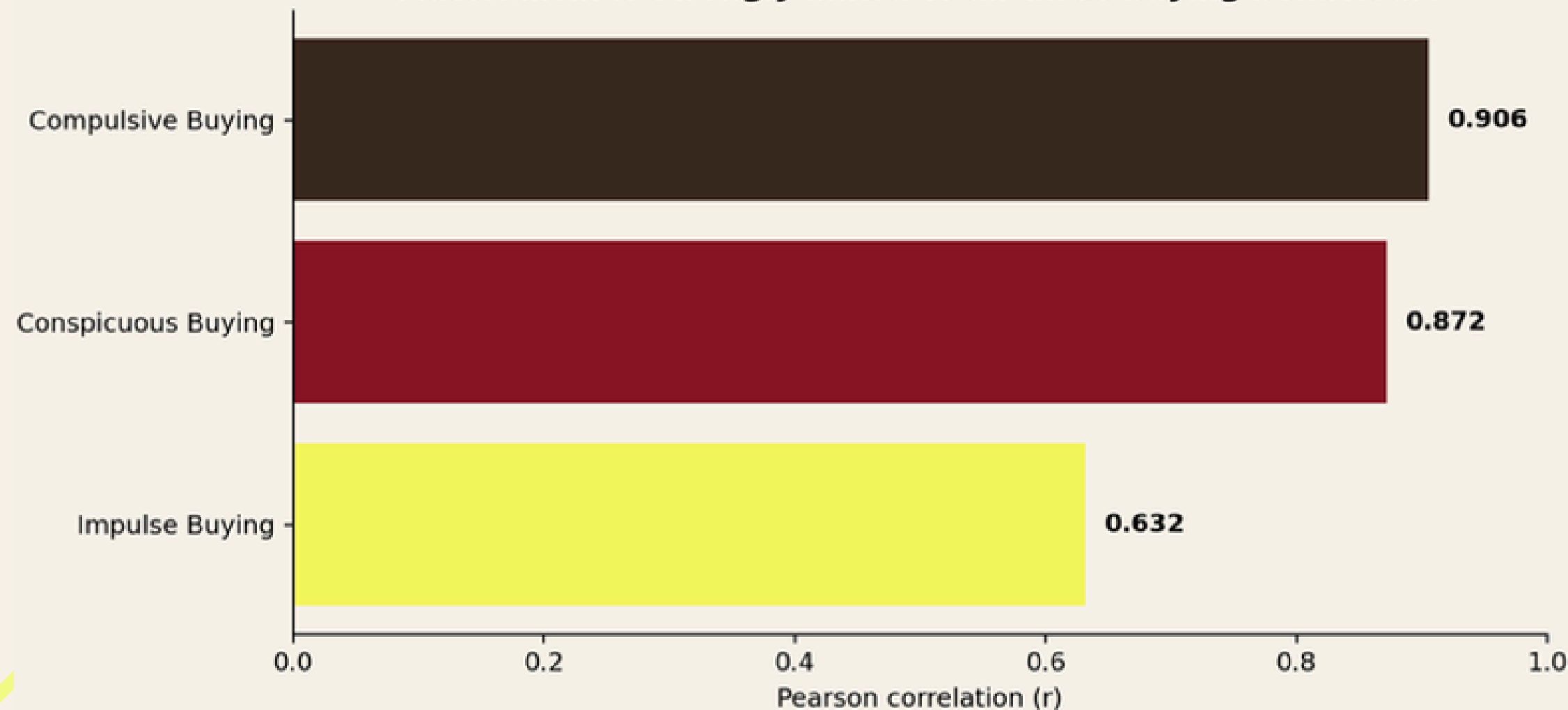


Strongest SMI relationship: Compulsive Buying ($r = 0.859$)
All four relationships are statistically significant ($p < 0.001$)

MATERIALISM IS A KEY BEHAVIOURAL LINK

Materialism shows strong positive relationships with compulsive, conspicuous and impulse buying.

Materialism is strongly linked to all three buying behaviours



CORRELATION STRENGTH

Compulsive Buying
 $r = 0.906$

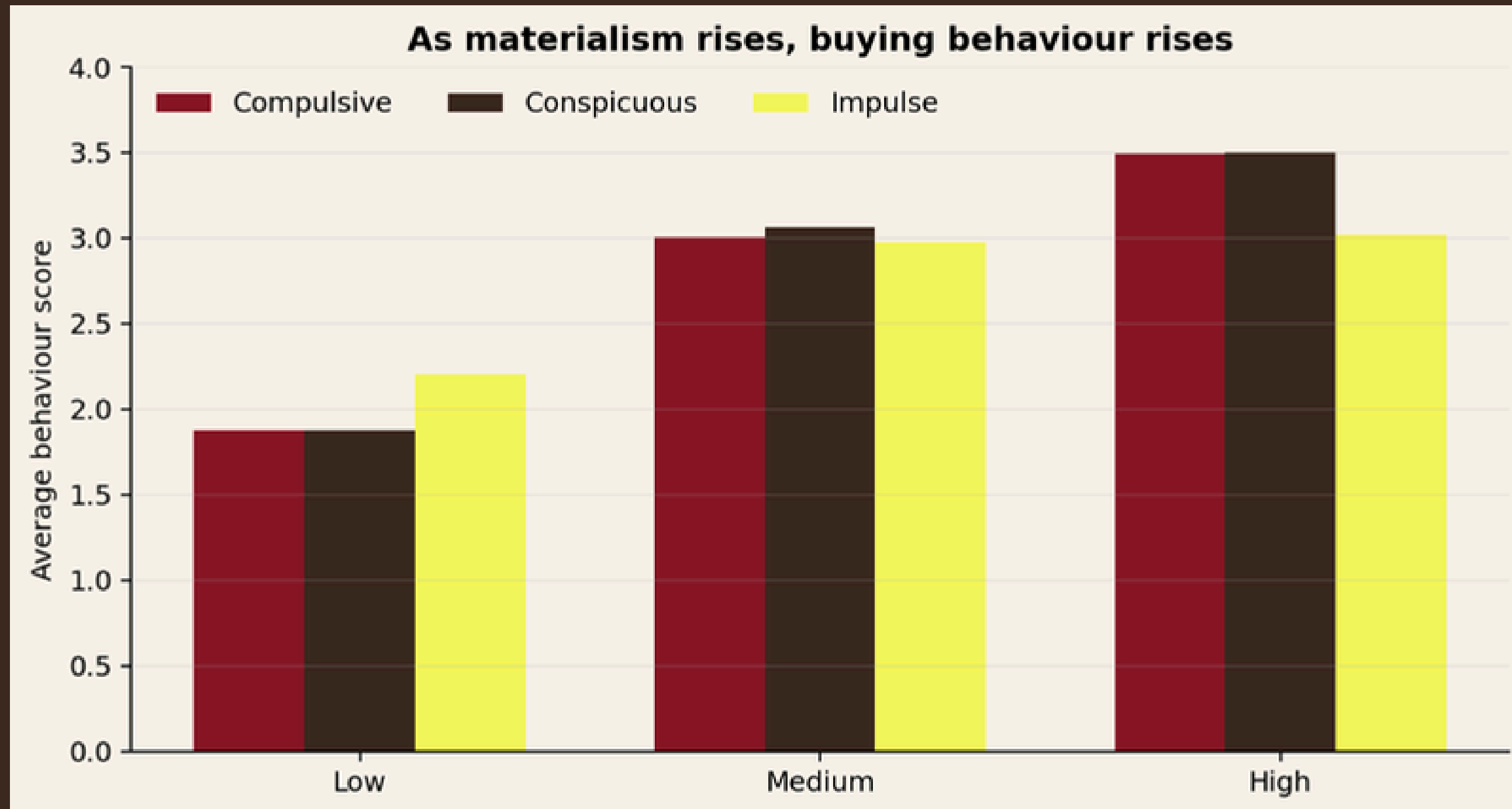
Conspicuous Buying
 $r = 0.872$

Impulse Buying
 $r = 0.632$

All $p < 0.001$

MATERIALISM GRADIENT: LOW → HIGH

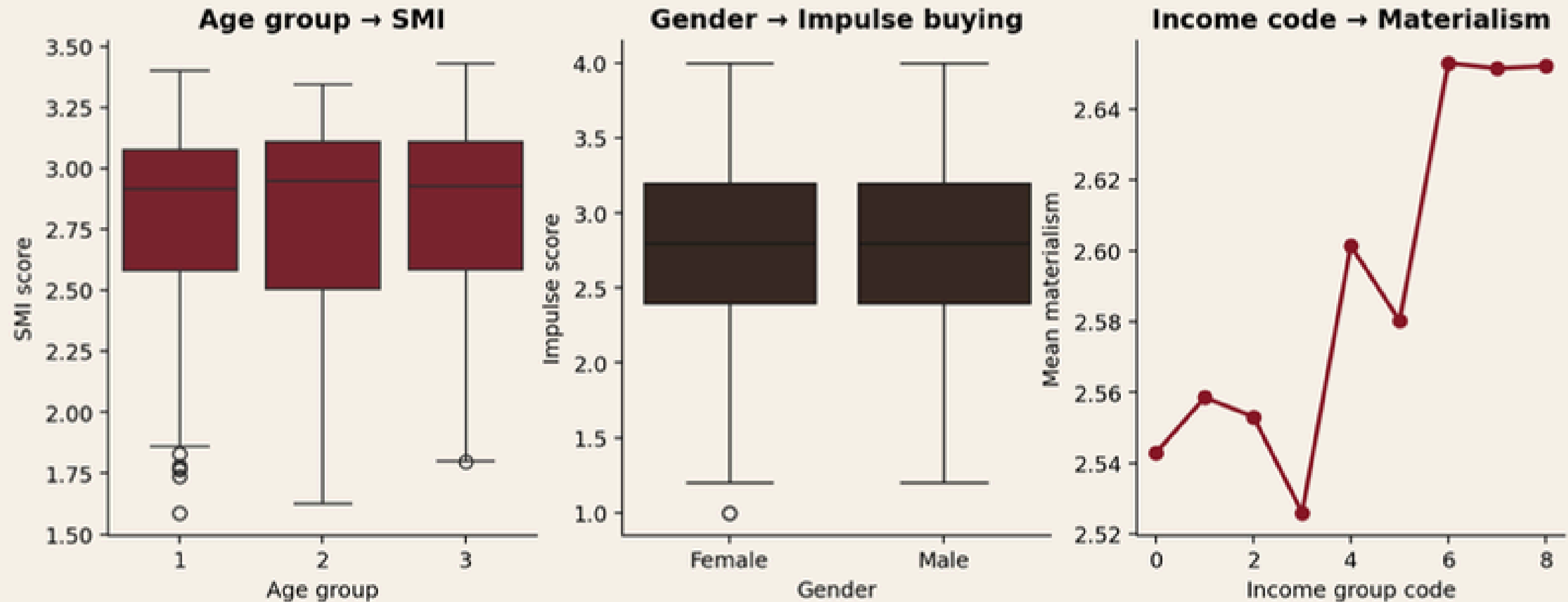
Respondents were split into tertiles based on materialism score.



High-materialism respondents show substantially higher average compulsive and conspicuous buying scores than low-materialism respondents.

DEMOGRAPHIC ANALYSIS

Age, gender and income comparisons add context to the main relationships.



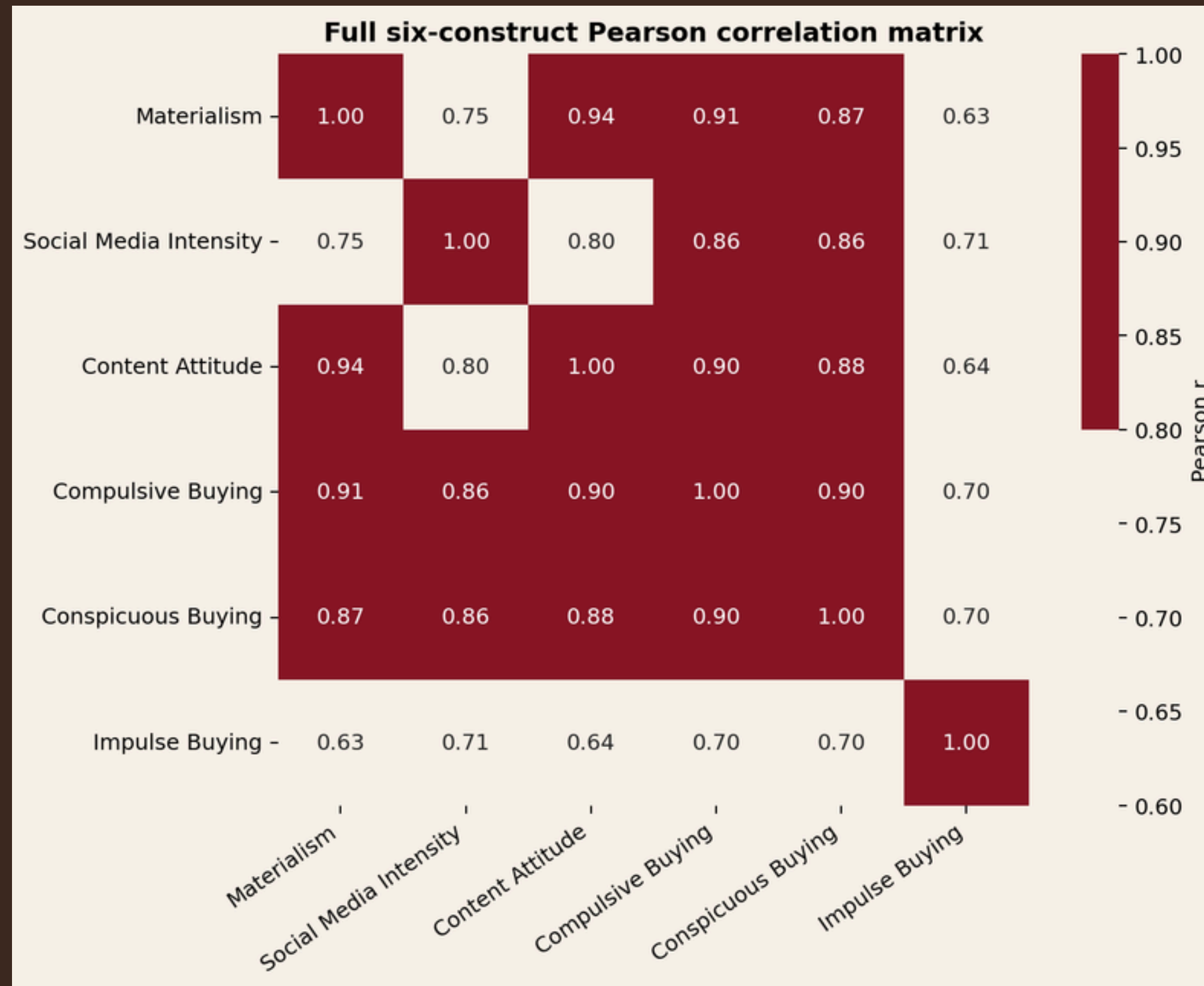
Age-group mean SMI: 2.75 / 2.76 / 2.76

Female vs Male impulse buying: 2.730 / 2.729

- Income is shown as the dataset's coded groups.
- Mean materialism varies modestly across codes.

FULL SIX-CONSTRUCT CORRELATION MATRIX

Every pair of the six core constructs is positively and significantly related.



STRONGEST LINKS

Materialism ↔ Content Attitude
 $r = 0.939$

Materialism ↔ Compulsive Buying
 $r = 0.906$

Compulsive Buying ↔ Conspicuous Buying
 $r = 0.903$

All 15 pairs: $p < 0.001$



THE CAVEAT



Correlation $\neq$ Causation

Our findings reveal strong relationships.
They do not prove that: Social media causes consumerism.

Why?

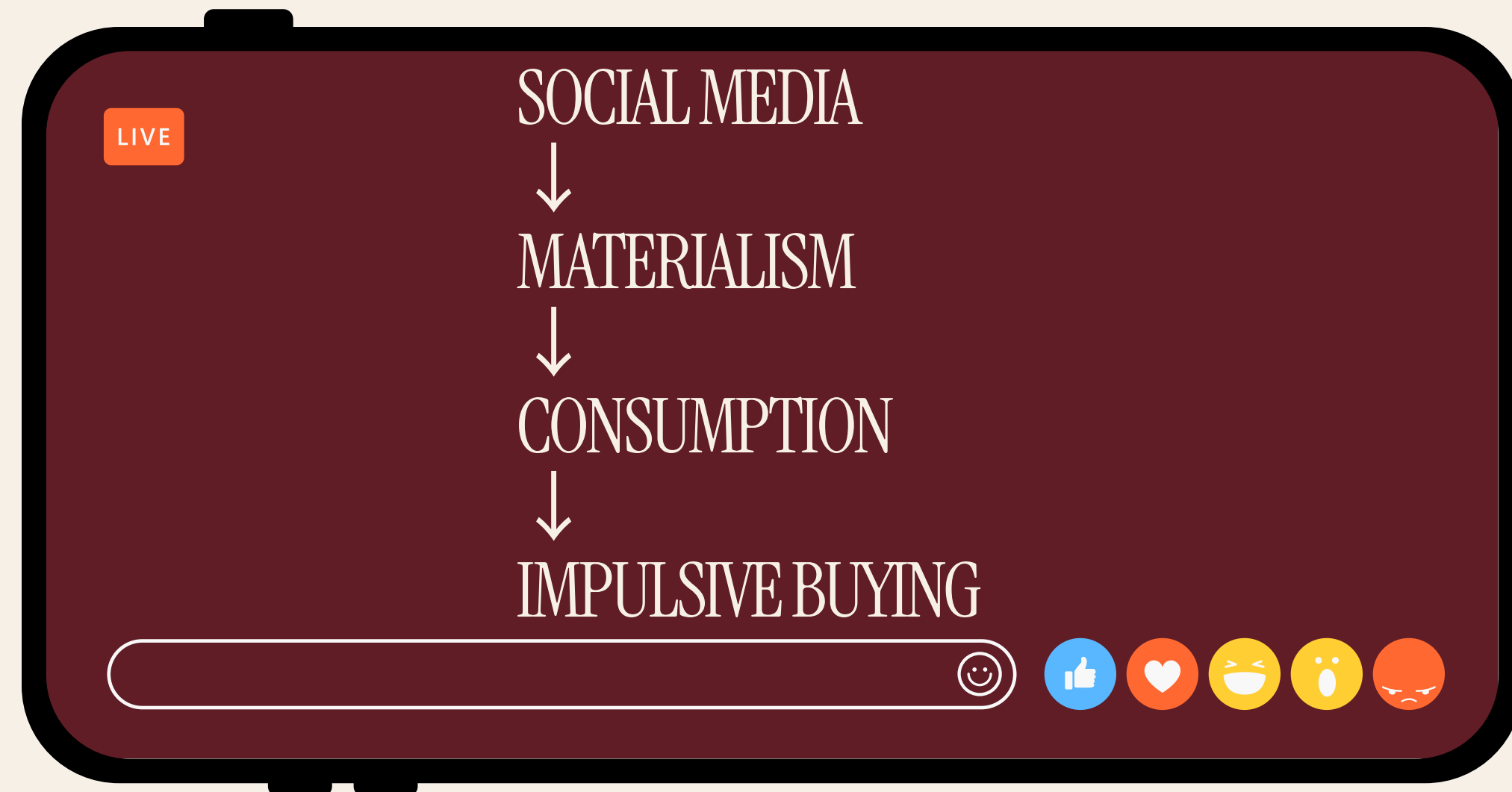
The data shows associations between variables, rather than establishing cause and effect.



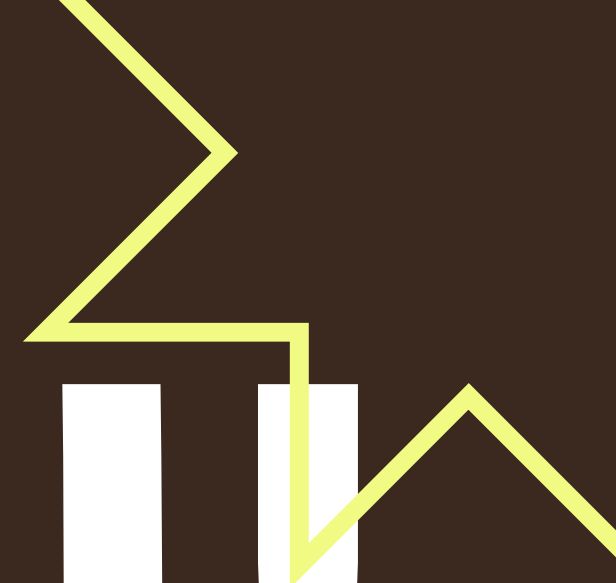
SO DOES SOCIAL MEDIA FUEL UP CONSUMERISM?

→ We can say that scrolling causes shopping.

→ But our data reveals strong connections between:



The scroll may not force us to buy. But it may be deeply connected to how we consume.



THANK YOU!



MADE BY:

Group 10

- K Medha Vibhavari - 2609021
 - Shreya Patel - 2609004
 - Nihaal Kaur - 2609011
- 
- 